

getting tested or being tested regularly enough to adequately screen for COVID-19. Augmenting that type of testing with smell testing could provide an inexpensive and distanced way of identifying people who have acquired COVID-19 and helping them to get treatment or isolation early on.” Roy Parker, a researcher from the University of Colorado has gone ahead and developed such a test, which costs less than 50 cents which is about ₹40. “We hope that it would allow for a fast and easy test that anyone can take anywhere and can be applied to anyplace that is using temperature screening as an inexpensive way to help avoid shutdowns, keep businesses open and decrease the terrible human toll,” Parker says.

18 DIGITAL FITNESS

The effect on the pandemic on the fitness industry has been so profound, that the year is being considered as a turning point for the industry. While the gyms had shut down, trainers began to use social media to put out workouts, that could be done at home over short bursts without using specialised equipment from the gym. Technology solutions followed to support fitness services remotely, through the use of technology, with a focus on being able to deliver individual services to each user. The pandemic managed to push an industry that was intensely physical, into cyberspace.

Amaresh Ojha, CEO & Founder of Glympik explains, “While the pandemic induced lockdown brought the industry to a standstill, it has become increasingly clear that the reason why many fitness studios were left in the cold was also due to delayed adoption of technology at scale by the industry. This is why, once the premises were shut, the only link between the members and the studio was severed. This is when new-age technology companies came to the rescue with best-in-class tech solutions like Traqade that helped gyms & studios re-establish this link online through live streaming and other means.”

Going forward, the integration with gyms and fitness centers is only expected to increase. Ojha goes on to add, “In 2021, we will witness a COVID-19 induced technological revolution at an unprecedented scale and it’s fair to say that the technological leap made by the industry in the process will dictate fitness trends of the future. This tech-led integration in the fitness value chain will also introduce greater personalisation, convenience, safety, and flexibility for members while helping fitness business owners to deliver a consistent brand experience across channels. In fact, innovative solutions like contactless technology will emerge as one of the biggest competitive advantages in the industry in 2021. But to reap the benefits of the current push for fitness, the industry will need to stay focused on maintaining the highest standards of hygiene and efficiently embracing the plethora of these tech-driven innovations.”

Mr Jitendra Chouksey, Founder of FITTR explains how the rapid digitisation of gyms was a matter of survival, “globally, it has been one of the most unprecedented and challenging years for everyone. Businesses across sectors have been grappling with the economic consequences of the pandemic, and the fitness industry is no exception. The effects were more pronounced during the lockdown, with the temporary closure of gyms and fitness studios. It not only disrupted the liquidity of these businesses but also impacted the employment of its workforce. In spite of these challenges, the fitness industry saw an opportunity in digital adoption, making 2020 a turning point. From being an industry that was largely dependent on physical, on-ground fitness centers, it went online with an entire gamut of services. This was not only a necessity to stay relevant but also to survive. Today, many large and small players have begun offering virtual

workout sessions, nutrition consultations, and personal training, among other services.”

Going ahead, Chouksey then goes on to focus on the importance of choosing the right mix of digital and physical services: “During this period, as a tech-enabled platform, Fittr has strengthened its business considerably. The company has clocked a growth of 30 per cent month-on-month, an 80 per cent cumulative revenue retention rate



Shilpa Shetty won the internet by posting a steady stream of workouts and yoga poses on Instagram, throughout the pandemic

over a 24-month period, and crossed \$10 million in annual revenues. What’s more, Fittr has achieved all this profitability with zero customer acquisition costs. It is also one of the few start-ups that has hired during the pandemic, without any lay-offs for its existing employees. 2020 has been about sustenance and survival. This year, companies that invested in digital transformations and tech became stronger than ever. Moving forward, 2021 is expected to be about new business models - leveraging a mix of online and offline offerings, innovations, revival, and strengthening of businesses.”

19 TELEMEDICINE

Given the limited technologies available to them, doctors on the ground still managed to provide consultations using WhatsApp videos and Google